

Portuguese, Step by Step, Root by Root

An etymology-driven curriculum, built one word at a time

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This edition compiled incrementally — new chapters added as they
are written.

Companion practice lessons live alongside this book at
code/learning/human-languages/portuguese/lessons/

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Preface

This is the Portuguese volume of a wider project, written for someone starting from zero whose only shared language is English. Portuguese is taught one word at a time, each taken apart — traced to its root (usually Latin), then forward to the English cousins you already own. *obrigado* (“thanks”) turns out to be English *obligated*; *tarde* (“afternoon”) is *tardy*; *noite* (“night”) is the *noct-* of *nocturnal*.

Portuguese is a daughter of Latin, and often the one that wore its words down *most*: the article *ille* eroded all the way to a single letter, *o*. Where a sister language (Spanish, French, Italian) makes a contrast vivid, the book supplies it in full — no prior knowledge of them assumed.

Three things shape every lesson: one word per lesson, gone deep; the widest *honest* web of cousins; and the cultural or idiomatic reason a thing is said. Pronunciation is a short reference at the front, never a gate. Released under CC BY-SA 4.0.

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Portuguese pronunciation — a reference

Not to be read before the lessons — each lesson gives the sounds its word needs. This page gathers them. Portuguese spelling is fairly regular, but its **nasal vowels** and soft consonants surprise English speakers.

The traps for an English speaker

- **Nasal vowels.** A vowel before *m/n* (or under a tilde) is sent through the nose: *bom* = *bõ*, *sim* (“yes”) = *sĩ*, *pão* (“bread”) = *pãw*. English has no exact match — hum the vowel.
- **Vowels reduce.** Unstressed *e* often vanishes to a whisper or *i*; final *o* sounds like *u* (*obrigado* ≈ “oh-bree-GAH-doo”).
- **s** between vowels = *z*; at the end of a syllable it is often *sh* (European) or *s* (most of Brazil).
- **lh** = the *lli* of *million*; **nh** = the *ny* of *canyon*; **ç** = *s*.
- **r** at the start of a word, or **rr**, is a strong guttural (like a Scottish/French *r* or even an *h*); a single *r* between vowels is a light tap.

Stress

Usually the second-to-last syllable; a written accent (*á*, *â*, *ã*) marks any exception (*olá*, *café*, *avô*).

Portuguese in the Romance family

Portuguese, Spanish, French, and Italian are all worn-down Latin. Portuguese often eroded the most (the article *ille* → *o*); it turned Latin *-ct-* into *-it-* (*noite*, like French *nuit*); and it kept *dies* close (*o dia*, like Spanish *día*). The lessons draw these contrasts as they arise.

Chapter 1

Greetings

The Portuguese greetings, built from their pieces — a word for “good,” the day-parts, the article that carries gender, and a “thank you” that changes with *who is speaking*. Each word is taken apart to its root and its English cousins. *Practice lessons: lessons/PT-C01-*.md.*

1.1 *olá* — “hi”

Sounds you’ll need

oh-LAH — stress on the second syllable (the written accent on *á* marks it). The *l* is clear, the *a* open.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

olá (“hi”) is a friendly interjection of uncertain birth — probably a natural call for attention (like English *hello* / *hallo*), possibly reinforced by Arabic *w-Allāh* (“by God”) during the centuries of Moorish Iberia. Unlike most Portuguese words, it has *no* clean Latin root: some greetings are just sounds. Spanish, its close sibling, has the near- identical *hola*.

Why it’s said this way

olá is friendly and fairly neutral — fine for most people, though for real formality or a first meeting you add *bom dia* / *boa tarde*, built next. In Brazil you’ll also hear *oi* for a casual “hi.”

1.2 *bom* / *boa* — “good”

Sounds you’ll need

bom is **nasal** — *bõ*, the *m* not fully closed, the vowel sent through the nose. **boa** (feminine) is a clear *BOH-ah*.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

bom / **boa** (“good”) ← Latin *bonus* / *bona* → English **bonus**, **bonanza**. Spanish, another daughter of Latin, made *bueno* / *buena*; Portuguese wore *bonus* down further, to the little nasal *bom*.

Grammar Lens

bom / **boa** agrees with its noun: *bom* (m.), *boa* (f.), *bons* / *boas* (pl.) — Latin’s adjective agreement, alive across the Romance family. So it’s *bom dia* (m.) but *boa tarde* (f.).

1.3 *o* / *a* — “the,” and an article worn to a single letter

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

o (masculine “the”) and **a** (feminine) ← Latin *ille* / *illa* (“that one”). Here Portuguese did something striking: it wore the word down *further than any of its sisters* — Latin *ille* → Italian *il* → Spanish *el* → Portuguese just **o**. The whole demonstrative has eroded to a single vowel. (English “the” is Germanic, unrelated.)

Grammar Lens

Every Portuguese noun is **masculine or feminine** — Latin’s genders collapsed to two. Learn each noun *with* its article: *o* for masculine, *a* for feminine. Beware the trap coming next: *o dia* (“the day”) is *masculine* even though it ends in *-a*.

1.4 *dia* — “day”

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

o dia (masc.) ← Latin *dies* (“day”) — taken almost straight, like Spanish *día*. Cousins straight from *dies*: **di**urnal, **di**ary; and, through the derived *diurnum*, English **j**ournal and **j**ourney (which is why Italian *giorno* and French *jour* look so different — they took the longer road).

Grammar Lens

A gender trap. *dia* ends in *-a* — the usual feminine signal — yet it is *masculine*: *o dia*. This is a fossil of its Latin origin (*dies* was masculine), and a reminder to learn each noun *with* its article rather than guessing gender from the ending.

1.5 *bom dia* — “good day / good morning,” assembled

bom (“good”) + *dia* (“day”) = **bom dia**, “good day” — and, in practice, “good morning”: it’s the greeting until noon.

Why it’s said this way

bom dia is the polite, all-purpose morning hello — safe with anyone. After midday it gives way to *boa tarde*, and after dark to *boa noite*. (Spanish pluralises the blessing — *buenos días* — where Portuguese keeps it singular, *bom dia*.)

1.6 *tarde* — “afternoon,” and *boa tarde*

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

a tarde (fem.) ← Latin *tardus* (“slow, late”) — the same *tardus* behind English **tardy** and **retard** (“to slow”). Portuguese named the afternoon after its *lateness*, exactly as Spanish did with the identical *tarde*. **boa tarde** = “good afternoon.”

1.7 *noite* — “night,” and *boa noite*

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

a noite (fem.) ← Latin *noctem* (*noct-*) → English **nocturnal**, **equinox**. Portuguese turned the Latin *-ct-* into **-it-** (*noite*) — the same change French made (*nuît*), while Spanish went *-ch-* (*noche*) and Italian *-tt-* (*notte*).

Latin	Portuguese	Spanish	French	Italian
<i>noctem</i>	<i>noite</i>	<i>noche</i>	<i>nuît</i>	<i>notte</i>
<i>factum</i>	<i>feito</i>	<i>hecho</i>	<i>fait</i>	<i>fatto</i>

boa noite = “good night” — used both as an evening greeting and as the farewell for bed.

1.8 *obrigado* / *obrigada* — “thank you,” i.e. “[I am] obliged”

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

obrigado / **obrigada** (“thanks”) ← Latin *obligātus* (“bound, obliged”), from *ob-* (“to”) + *ligāre* (“to bind”). It is the *same* word as English **obligated**, and shares its root with **oblige**, **obligation**, and (via *ligare*) **ligament** and **liable**. To say *obrigado* is to say “I am *bound* to you” — indebted by your kindness.

Grammar Lens

It agrees with the speaker, not the listener. Because *obrigado* literally means “[I am] obliged,” it takes the gender of *whoever is speaking*: a man says **obrigado**, a woman says **obrigada** — no matter who they’re thanking. This is unlike the other tracks’ adjectives (which match the noun); here the adjective matches *you*.

1.9 The day of greetings

Portuguese	English
<i>olá</i>	hi
<i>bom dia</i>	good morning
<i>boa tarde</i>	good afternoon
<i>boa noite</i>	good night
<i>obrigado / obrigada</i>	thank you

Every piece traced: *bom* (*bonus*), *dia* (*dies*), *tarde* (*tardus*, “late”; English *tardy*), *noite* (*noctem*, -ct-→-it-), *obrigado* (*obligātus*, “obliged”). And two Portuguese habits: the article eroded to a single vowel (*o* / *a*), and “thank you” agrees with the *speaker* (*obrigado* / *obrigada*). Next chapter: introducing yourself — *o meu nome é...* / *chamo-me...* — and Portuguese’s *tu* vs. *você* (familiar / polite “you”).